STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 04 · Stop Waiting

Transcript · Wes Hart

I've got to start with a confession about my garage. There's a stack of floor tile out there. Enough to redo our downstairs bathroom. I bought it on sale. Forty percent off. Which, at the time, felt like the hard part. It's been out there long enough that nobody in my house calls it the tile anymore. We call it the table. My wife sets the groceries on it. The tile has become furniture. Last month she put a lamp on it. I think we're past the point of no return. Anyway. It's good to be in a room with you guys again. Pull your chair in a little. Closer than feels natural. If this is your first lesson, jump right in. Nothing we said before is a test you missed.

Here's where we left it. We laid four marks on the table, the kind of things people can see on a man because he keeps doing them. And we stayed a long time with the last one. Doing the good thing and letting God be the one who notices. Some of you have been doing one quiet thing since then and not telling anybody. Good. Don't tell me either. That was kind of the point.

This lesson goes back to the front of the line. The first mark. And I'll put it plainly, because it's the whole hour. A steadfast man stops waiting. In kitchen words, he won't sit his own life out.

That stack of tile is a small picture of it. It's not broken. It's not lost. It's just waiting on me. And I've let it wait so long it quit looking like a decision.

I'd bet every man in here has a stack of tile somewhere. Yours might not be in the garage. Yours might be a conversation you keep, uh, walking around.

Now, when you hear the word passive, you probably picture a guy on a couch. Remote on his chest. Blinds down. He's not the one I'm worried about. Everybody can see him. Including him. Honestly, that guy's got a better shot than most of us. At least he knows he's on the couch. The man I'm worried about is up before the alarm. He's good at his job. He's the one people call. His truck has jumper cables and a tarp and a spare everything. If your car dies in a parking lot, he's the guy you want walking by. And there's still a short list in his life he's been going to get to for years. Not the gutters. The big ones. The call back to the doctor. The apology he owes his sister. The friend who's drinking again, and doesn't know that he knows. Let me see a hand. How many of you have got one of those sitting in your head right now? No details. Just a hand. Yeah. Keep it up a second and look around. That's not a room full of lazy men. That's a room full of busy ones. Men who'd drive across town at midnight for a buddy with a flat. You can put your hands down. And busy is the best hiding place I know of. Nobody ever gets in trouble for being needed. Busy gets you thanked. Busy gets you a plaque. I've never seen anybody get a plaque for finally calling his brother. I answer work email in about ninety seconds. I'm, uh, kind of proud of that. My brother left me a voicemail back in the spring. I still haven't called him back. I've listened to it six times. That's six times I could've just called him.

I want to read you one of the first questions God ever asked a man. Genesis three, verse nine. But the Lord God called to the man, Where are you?

Here's what gets me about that. God wasn't lost. He wasn't out there squinting through the trees going, Adam? Buddy? He knew exactly where the man was standing. So the question wasn't for God. It was for the man. And notice who He called to. Not the serpent. Not the tree. The man. He came looking for the one He'd put in charge of that garden. Uh, that's still how it works. When something's drifting in a house, God doesn't usually start by asking the kids. You only ask a question you already know the answer to for one reason. You want the other guy to hear himself say it. It's not about information. It's about ownership. I do it with my kids. Where are your shoes? I know where they are. They're in the middle of the hallway, right where I'm about to step in the dark. I'm not asking for directions. I'm asking them to walk over there and deal with it. You with me?

That's how God comes after a man who's parked. He doesn't send a lecture. He sends a question. A lecture, you can argue with. A question, you have to answer. And it isn't a trick. It's an invitation to quit standing behind all the good stuff and answer from where you actually are. Some of you are standing in a very full life. And on one thing, you haven't moved in years. Not because you don't care. Because moving would cost you something, and standing still hasn't sent a bill yet. He knows which thing. You — you already know it too.

Here's the tricky part. Waiting hardly ever calls itself waiting. It borrows a better word. Something that sounds good on a Sunday. Most days, it goes by patience. I'm giving it time. Sometimes that's true. Some things do need a minute. A fence post needs a minute to set. But a lot of the time a man's asking the calendar to do a job only he can do. The calendar can't apologize to your sister. It just turns the page. And your sister's still sitting on the other side of it. Or it goes by peace. That one sounds almost holy. I don't want to stir anything up. So the house stays calm. Calm, and a little lonely. Like a waiting room with nice magazines. If you're married, you know this one. There's a thing she brought up once. Maybe twice. And you nodded, and you said, yeah, we should talk about that. That was, uh, three Christmases ago. She hasn't brought it up since. Not because it got fixed. Because she figured out where it goes when she does. You're calling that peace. She's calling it something else.

I mean, peace is when a thing gets settled. This is when a thing gets shelved.

Listen. Some of you went quiet for a reason. Maybe you grew up in a loud house, where the next thing said out loud was always the wrong thing. You spoke up once, and it went bad, and quiet started to feel like the smart play. I'm not gonna bark at you for that. It kept you safe once. I get that. But if the danger's gone and the quiet stayed, that's not wisdom anymore. It's just a habit with good manners.

Sometimes it goes by humility. Who am I to bring it up? I'm not the expert. Somebody else is closer to it. You're her husband. That's who. You're his dad. You're the guy who saw it. If you saw it, you're already in it.

And sometimes it goes by getting ready. This one's mine. I researched kayaks for about two years. Read the reviews. Watched the videos. Knew the weight of every model down to the ounce. I own zero kayaks. I have never been more prepared to not be on a lake. I could tell you which paddle to buy. I just couldn't tell you what the water feels like. A man can get really good at studying a thing he never does. And that's fine for kayaks. It's not fine for your marriage. Or your kid. Or the friend who's drinking. I know guys who've read three books on being a dad and haven't asked their kid a real question since spring.

Some guys do this with church, too. They're gonna come back. They're looking at, uh, a few places. They've been looking at a few places for three years.

If you're young, or you're single, there's a special version of this one. It sounds like, once I. Once I get the better job. Once I find the right girl. Once I've got a little money saved. Once I've got my, uh, head on straight. And somehow that sentence never gets to the second half. I mean, nobody's coming with a permission slip that says you can start your own life now. You started it a while ago. And the man you'll be in ten years is getting built right now, on the days you keep calling practice. It's already running.

And then there's the one with the best excuse of all. Faith. I'm waiting on the Lord. Look. Scripture tells us to wait on the Lord, and I won't take that from you. It's all over the Psalms. Some of you honestly don't know the next step. That's real. Ask Him. Ask a brother. Stay on your feet while you ask.

But there's another kind. Where the next step is sitting right there, and we pin God's name on the delay. That's a heavy name to pin on something. He never signed it. Joshua eighteen, verse three. So Joshua said to the Israelites: How long will you wait before you begin to take possession of the land that the Lord, the God of your ancestors, has given you?

Hear that last part. Has given you. The land was already theirs. God had done his part. The promising part. The going-ahead part. All of it. They were camped out waiting to feel like it. Not waiting on God. Waiting on themselves. Sound familiar? So here's a test, and it isn't clever. You can do it in the truck. When you say you're waiting on God, ask whether some piece of it already has your name on it. If it does, do that piece. The piece you can see. Not the whole map. You can trust Him for the rain and still put the seed in the ground. And ask yourself Joshua's question. How long. Not a mood. A number. Months. Years. I did this with the tile, by the way. Eleven months. For tile. A thing I could've finished in a weekend. I had to go dig up the, uh, order confirmation. Be honest, because rounding down is just one more way to wait. Fair?

I didn't see this next part coming. The people near you learn your wait. Even if you never say a word about it. My daughter asked me to put a shelf up in her room. Simple job. Two brackets, one board. I've hung heavier things with worse tools. I said, this weekend, kiddo. I said it a few weekends in a row. Well, more than a few. One morning my phone buzzes. Middle of a meeting. It's a calendar invite. From my own kid. Subject line. Dad, the shelf. Saturday, ten a.m. She even set a reminder. Fifteen minutes before. I laughed. And then I didn't. Because she's twelve years old, and she'd already figured out that asking me wasn't enough. She had to manage me. And she's good at it. She's better at it than my boss. That's what a wait does to the people around you. They start guessing. They're quiet about it. Is he mad? Is he tired? Does he even care about this? And the answer is yes, I did care. I just cared from a distance. And after a while they quit guessing and just build their life around the hole where you should be. Kids do it. Wives do it. Friends do it fastest. A friend who can't reach you just, uh, stops trying and calls it being busy too. I put the shelf up that Saturday. Ten a.m. She stood in the doorway the whole time, handing me screws like a surgical nurse. It took twenty minutes. It's— it's twenty minutes. And the shelf wasn't really the point. She didn't need a shelf that bad. She needed to know that when she asked, I'd move. That's what I'd been protecting for a month.

Let me tell you about a man I'll call Curtis. Curtis coached youth baseball for close to twenty years. If you had a kid in that town, Curtis probably taught him to quit flinching at a fastball. Good man. Honest man. Showed up to every practice with a bucket of balls and a thermos. A few years before I met him, his wife asked if they could go see a counselor. Nothing was on fire. She just felt like they'd turned into roommates. Nice roommates. Curtis said, sure. After the season. And he meant it. Then fall ball started. Then a travel team needed a coach. Then spring came back around, the way it does. Every time she asked, he had a real answer. The kids needed him. And they did. He told me the worst day wasn't a fight. The worst day was the day she quit asking. He came home one night, and she'd—she'd moved her things into the guest room. No yelling. She just said, I'm tired of waiting on the season to be over.

Curtis sat on that for a couple of days. He told me he kept waiting to feel ready. Like there'd be a morning he'd wake up knowing exactly what to say. That morning never showed up. What showed up was a Thursday. He got to the field early, like always. Sat down in the dugout with his phone in his hand. And he called the counselor's office. Ball bag at his feet. He said his hands were sweating so bad he almost dropped the phone in the dirt. The lady on the line said, we've got Monday at four. He said, I've got practice. And then he heard himself. He said, no. We'll be there. He told his wife that night. She didn't cry. She didn't hug him. She just said, okay. That was it. The first appointment was, his word, awful. Long silences. He said he'd rather take a line drive off the shin. But they went back. And they kept going back. About a year in, she told him something he wrote down. She said, I quit waiting on you a long time ago. I'm glad you came anyway.

Stay with me here, because I don't want you to miss it. Curtis wasn't short on love. He was short on the first move. And he'd been calling that shortage by a nice name. The kids need me. He waited to feel ready, and ready never came first. It doesn't. Ready shows up after you move. Usually a while after. Sometimes a year after. And late still counted. I want the guys who feel late to hear that. Late isn't the same thing as too late. Curtis made that call three years behind. It still mattered. And here's the other part. The call took four minutes. Three years of waiting, and the move itself was four minutes on a dugout bench. Most of what you're waiting on is like that. The dread is huge. The move is small. It's, what's the word, it's lopsided. We just, you know, never measure the move. We only measure the dread.

James doesn't give us a soft place to land on this. James four, verse seventeen. If anyone, then, knows the good they ought to do and doesn't do it, it is sin for them.

That's a hard verse. It takes away the middle. We like to think there's a middle. Not doing the wrong thing, not doing the right thing, just sort of, uh, holding. James says there isn't one. If you know it, and you're sitting on it, God has a word for that. And the word isn't careful. So here's what we do with it. Name the thing small enough that a morning could hold it. Your whole marriage is too big for a Thursday. A four-minute phone call isn't. Then find the smallest move that's still a real move. Pulling up the number isn't it. Hitting call is. And do it before noon. I know myself. By about three in the afternoon, my excuses have had all day to get dressed. They sound very responsible by then. Right? And expect it to feel wrong. You've practiced waiting for years. The first real move is gonna feel like you cut in line. You didn't. You just finally took your turn.

Okay. The same wait shows up in every kind of house. It just changes its name at the door. In a young man's apartment, it's called someday. Someday's a busy guy. He's never home. With a new baby, it's called when things settle down. They won't. I checked. With a big career, it's called next quarter. And next quarter has a next quarter. For the guy who's worn out at church, it's called let somebody else. There's always a somebody else. Until one day there isn't. After a divorce, it's called when I'm not so angry. Some of you are still waiting to feel fair about it. You might wait a long time. And I'll say this one gently. If you're hurting, go slow. One small true thing is plenty. A text. A coffee. Frozen isn't the same as healed, but you don't have to thaw all at once. For the older men, it's called nobody asked me. The job's done. The kids are grown. And you're waiting on somebody to invite you to matter. They're not going to. Not because you don't matter. They just don't think to. Younger men don't know how to knock. So go find one. Ask him how he's actually doing, and then, uh, stay for the answer.

I know a man in his seventies who got tired of waiting to be asked. He just started showing up early to set out the chairs. Within a month, three young guys were showing up early too. They didn't come for the chairs.

Different houses. Same wait. And I'll tell you who's got every right to wait on you. Your Father. He's the only one in the house who's allowed to. And He's been more patient than any of us deserve.

Let me bring this in. If you only hold on to one thing, hold on to this. Waiting almost always wears a nicer name. Patience. Peace. Humility. Getting ready. Even faith. And under the nice name there's something you already know is yours, and you haven't touched it.

You could find it with the lights off.

We've been circling four marks. A man who won't let his life idle. Who shoulders his own load. Who walks into the hard thing ahead of the people he loves. Who's content to be paid by God. Today was the first one. A steadfast man stops waiting. And it's the one the other three get stuck behind.

What I want you walking out with isn't guilt. Guilt is heavy, and it doesn't move anything. It just sits there with you. I want you walking out with one name and one move. Small enough to do the minute you walk out.

Not a new you. Just one thing you quit walking past.

The tile's coming off the table this Saturday, by the way. My wife has heard that before. More than once. So now I've got a room full of witnesses.

Let me pray for us, and then the rest of this hour belongs to you.

Father, you heard every name that went through every head in here. You know how long. Some of us have waited so long it feels like furniture. Give us four minutes of courage. On a real day, before lunch. Give us the first move before we feel ready, and meet us on the other side of it. And if a man in here isn't sure about you yet, be patient with him the way you've been patient with us. And let him see you're worth moving toward. Amen.

Your workbook has three questions for this part. You'll work them with the men around you, not with me. I'll be around, but I'm not gonna hover. The first one is simple, and it isn't easy. What's the one

thing you've been going to get to the longest? And put a number on how long. Whatever's true, not whatever sounds better. The second one is about the people near you. Who's guessing right now, because you won't move? Say the name at the table. Not the whole story. Just the name. And the third one is the one that matters Monday morning. What's the smallest real move you can make on it before noon? Not the whole conversation. The first sentence. The first call.

When a man at your table says his number out loud, don't flinch, and don't fix it. And don't top it with your own. He just did the hard part. You don't have to agree it's a big deal. You just have to hear it. If you're working through this on your own, same three questions. Write them out. Don't just think them. Then text one man your move, and ask him to check on you.

Do it before you pull out of the parking lot. The drive home is where good intentions go to take a nap.

In the back of this part there's a line to copy out in your own hand. Where are you? He already knows. Answer Him on your feet.

Put it where you'll see it before noon. The bathroom mirror works. Unless your bathroom's still waiting on tile.

Alright. That's me done talking. Chairs up. Find your men. Pull them in close. And at every table, somebody be the first to say his number.